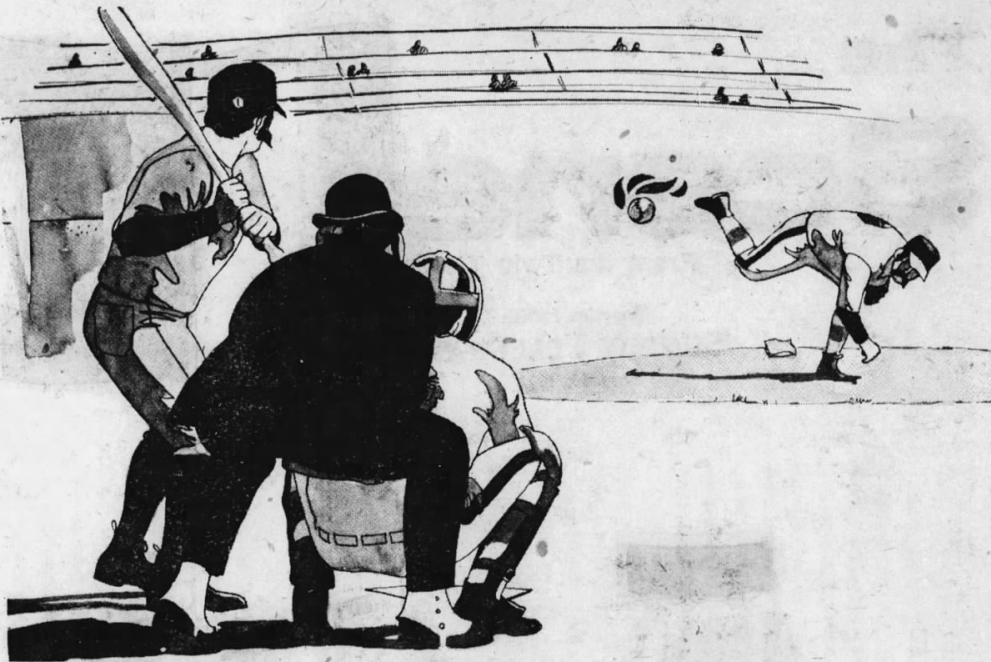


THE SCENE, Elmira, N.Y., Aug. 13, 1972 2



Elmira Baseball

50 Years on a Shoestring

By AL MALLETTE

Crisis and survival.

Those are the big words in Elmira's 50 seasons of professional baseball — an anniversary which the Pioneers will celebrate Monday night with festivities at Dunn Field.

Elmira has had its glory days and its star performers.

Its teams have won four pennants, contended in eight Governor's Cups (winning five) and three divisional or split-season playoffs.

But it has been a battle of survival—two park fires, two major floods, a reported "sellout" to gamblers, and at least a dozen "save Elmira

baseball" drives over those 50 seasons.

Elmira is the lone city remaining in a league that was born in February 1923 at Elmira's old Rathbun Hotel.

In its early days the league was known as the New York-Penn (NYP). It began with a Class B classification and moved to Class A in 1933.

Tommy Richardson changed the name to Eastern in 1938, and it has remained that way since. Classification has moved up another notch to AA.

Elmira had been out of pro baseball about five years in 1923 when a local group got together with men from Binghamton, Wilkes-Barre, Scranton, York and Williamsport.

The reason was the interest Twin Tier fans had shown in the semi-pro Arctics, Eclipse and Patch.

Buffalo agreed to furnish ballplayers, to actually run the club.

Buffalo sent in one good ball player — Charlie Babbington — as player-manager. He hit about .420 as an Elmira Red Jacket — but none of his mates hit their weight. Babbington was traded to York in mid-season and Elmira ended that first year with a 36-91 record, entrenched solidly in last place.

That led to the first crisis.

Buffalo dropped the franchise and no one bothered to pick it up. So a local group headed by Mort Sullivan bought the franchise from Buffalo, changed the name to the Colonels and set up shop independently.

The group bucked the semi-pros for attendance and weathered reports of "sellouts" to gamblers in 1928 and a stadium fire in the late Twenties. Finally it was forced to throw in the sponge after two months of the 1931 season owing \$25,000.

At about that time Branch Rickey was putting his "farm system" into operation for the St. Louis Cardinals. He had signed a bundle of players. When league boss Perry Farrell explained the Elmira plight, Rickey sent in Gabe Paul and others to set up shop with a batch of baby Cardinals.

The talent was too young for a league that boasted hundreds of veteran players. The Red Wings were flops in the standings and at the gate, and the Cards pulled up stakes after a dismal 1934 campaign.

Once again the battle for survival began.

Farrell couldn't come up with a farm agreement, so another local group, headed by Levi Ginsburg, Bill Lande, Art Hoffman and Mort Sullivan with behind-the-scenes work by Advertiser sports editor Glenn O. Sherwood, was organized to save baseball.

The men did.

The 1935 start was wobbly (the club of misfits was 2-25 after the first 27 games), but then player deals by Ginsburg and Lande began to pay off. They purchased (mostly with their own money) such as Lew Krausse, Jack Grossman, Joe Cicero, Art Graham, Nick Etten, Stan Sperry, Wally Novak, Jack Kimball, Gowell Chaset and Johnny Pasek.



The Cover

The color, excitement and pageantry of a drum corps performance are captured in this illustration by Peg Lyon.

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